SSC CGL — English Practice MCQs

174 solved questions across 9 topics — Synonyms/Antonyms, Idioms, One-Word Substitution, Spelling, Error Detection, Cloze, Sentence Improvement, Voice/Narration & Reading Comprehension. Each question has the answer and a one-line solution.

Synonyms & Antonyms

23 Q

EASY

Choose the SYNONYM of **Abundant**.

(a) Scarce (b) Plentiful (c) Empty (d) Rare

Answer: (b) Plentiful

> **Solution:** "Abundant" means existing in large quantities, i.e. plentiful. Scarce, empty and rare all denote shortage, so they are antonyms.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Brave**.

(a) Timid (b) Cowardly (c) Courageous (d) Weak

Answer: (c) Courageous

> **Solution:** "Brave" means showing courage, so courageous matches. Timid, cowardly and weak express the opposite quality.

Choose the ANTONYM of **Ancient**.

(a) Old (b) Antique (c) Modern (d) Aged

Answer: (c) Modern

> **Solution:** "Ancient" means belonging to the very distant past; its opposite is modern. Old, antique and aged are near-synonyms.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Happy**.

(a) Sad (b) Joyful (c) Gloomy (d) Angry

Answer: (b) Joyful

> **Solution:** "Happy" means feeling pleasure, so joyful is the match. Sad, gloomy and angry are unrelated negative emotions.

Choose the ANTONYM of **Victory**.

(a) Triumph (b) Success (c) Defeat (d) Win

Answer: (c) Defeat

> **Solution:** "Victory" is a win; its opposite is defeat. Triumph, success and win are synonyms of victory.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Begin**.

(a) Finish (b) Stop (c) Commence (d) End

Answer: (c) Commence

> **Solution:** "Begin" means to start; commence is a formal synonym. Finish, stop and end mean to conclude.

MEDIUM

Choose the SYNONYM of **Diligent**.

(a) Lazy (b) Hardworking (c) Careless (d) Idle

Answer: (b) Hardworking

> **Solution:** "Diligent" describes someone who works carefully and hard, so hardworking fits. Lazy, careless and idle are antonyms.

Choose the ANTONYM of **Generous**.

(a) Kind (b) Liberal (c) Stingy (d) Charitable

Answer: (c) Stingy

> **Solution:** "Generous" means willing to give freely; stingy means unwilling to give, the opposite. Kind, liberal and charitable are synonyms.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Candid**.

(a) Deceptive (b) Frank (c) Secretive (d) Cunning

Answer: (b) Frank

> **Solution:** "Candid" means open and honest in speech, i.e. frank. Deceptive, secretive and cunning suggest the opposite.

Choose the ANTONYM of **Transparent**.

(a) Clear (b) Obvious (c) Opaque (d) Plain

Answer: (c) Opaque

> **Solution:** "Transparent" means able to be seen through; opaque blocks light and view, the opposite. Clear, obvious and plain are synonyms.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Reluctant**.

(a) Eager (b) Willing (c) Unwilling (d) Keen

Answer: (c) Unwilling

> **Solution:** "Reluctant" means hesitant or unwilling to do something. Eager, willing and keen express enthusiasm, the opposite.

Choose the ANTONYM of **Humble**.

(a) Modest (b) Meek (c) Arrogant (d) Simple

Answer: (c) Arrogant

> **Solution:** "Humble" means modest about oneself; arrogant means proud and self-important, the opposite. Modest, meek and simple are synonyms.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Vivid**.

(a) Dull (b) Bright (c) Faint (d) Vague

Answer: (b) Bright

> **Solution:** "Vivid" means producing strong, clear images; bright captures this vividness. Dull, faint and vague indicate the opposite.

HARD

Choose the SYNONYM of **Ephemeral**.

(a) Permanent (b) Eternal (c) Transient (d) Lasting

Answer: (c) Transient

> **Solution:** "Ephemeral" means lasting a very short time; transient also means short-lived. Permanent, eternal and lasting denote durability.

Choose the ANTONYM of **Benevolent**.

(a) Kind (b) Malevolent (c) Gracious (d) Caring

Answer: (b) Malevolent

> **Solution:** "Benevolent" means well-meaning and kind; malevolent means wishing harm, the exact opposite. Kind, gracious and caring are synonyms.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Meticulous**.

(a) Careless (b) Sloppy (c) Painstaking (d) Hasty

Answer: (c) Painstaking

> **Solution:** "Meticulous" means showing great attention to detail; painstaking conveys the same care. Careless, sloppy and hasty are opposites.

Choose the ANTONYM of **Frugal**.

(a) Thrifty (b) Economical (c) Extravagant (d) Sparing

Answer: (c) Extravagant

> **Solution:** "Frugal" means careful with money; extravagant means spending lavishly, the opposite. Thrifty, economical and sparing are synonyms.

Choose the SYNONYM of **Audacious**.

(a) Timid (b) Bold (c) Fearful (d) Cautious

Answer: (b) Bold

> **Solution:** "Audacious" means showing a willingness to take bold risks; bold matches. Timid, fearful and cautious describe the opposite.

SSC PYQ PATTERN

> *(SSC CGL pattern)*

Select the most appropriate SYNONYM of the given word. **Lucid**

(a) Confusing (b) Clear (c) Murky (d) Obscure

Answer: (b) Clear

> **Solution:** "Lucid" means expressed clearly and easy to understand, so clear is correct. Confusing, murky and obscure are antonyms.

Select the most appropriate ANTONYM of the given word. **Optimistic**

(a) Hopeful (b) Cheerful (c) Pessimistic (d) Positive

Answer: (c) Pessimistic

> **Solution:** "Optimistic" means hopeful about the future; pessimistic, expecting the worst, is the opposite. Hopeful, cheerful and positive are synonyms.

Select the most appropriate SYNONYM of the given word. **Tedious**

(a) Exciting (b) Boring (c) Pleasant (d) Brief

Answer: (b) Boring

> **Solution:** "Tedious" means too long, slow and dull, hence boring. Exciting and pleasant are opposites; brief refers to length, not dullness.

Select the most appropriate ANTONYM of the given word. **Hostile**

(a) Aggressive (b) Unfriendly (c) Friendly (d) Antagonistic

Answer: (c) Friendly

> **Solution:** "Hostile" means unfriendly or aggressive; friendly is its opposite. Aggressive, unfriendly and antagonistic are synonyms.

Select the most appropriate SYNONYM of the given word. **Abolish**

(a) Establish (b) Create (c) Abolish-retain (d) Eradicate

Answer: (d) Eradicate

> **Solution:** "Abolish" means to formally put an end to something; eradicate (to root out completely) is the closest synonym. Establish and create are opposites.

> - Group words into **synonym families** (e.g. brave–bold–audacious–valiant) so one cue recalls many.

> - Learn the **prefix** signal: *mal-* = bad (malevolent), *bene-* = good (benevolent).

> - For antonyms, picture the **two extremes** of a scale (frugal ↔ extravagant).

> - Always re-read whether the question asks for synonym or antonym **before** marking.

One-Word Substitution

22 Q

EASY

One who studies the stars and planets.

(a) Astrologer (b) Astronaut (c) Astronomer (d) Geologist

Answer: (c) Astronomer

> **Solution:** An astronomer scientifically studies celestial bodies. An astrologer links stars to human affairs, an astronaut travels in space, a geologist studies the earth.

A person who cannot read or write.

(a) Illiterate (b) Ignorant (c) Innocent (d) Illegible

Answer: (a) Illiterate

> **Solution:** "Illiterate" precisely means unable to read or write. Ignorant means lacking knowledge, illegible describes unreadable writing, innocent is unrelated.

A place where animals are kept for public show.

(a) Zoo (b) Aquarium (c) Sanctuary (d) Den

Answer: (a) Zoo

> **Solution:** A zoo houses many kinds of animals for public viewing. An aquarium holds fish, a sanctuary protects wildlife in nature, a den is an animal's home.

A medicine that kills germs.

(a) Antiseptic (b) Antibiotic (c) Anaesthetic (d) Antidote

Answer: (a) Antiseptic

> **Solution:** An antiseptic destroys or prevents the growth of germs. An anaesthetic numbs sensation; an antidote counters poison; an antibiotic treats bacterial infection from within.

A person who writes for newspapers.

(a) Author (b) Journalist (c) Editor (d) Publisher

Answer: (b) Journalist

> **Solution:** A journalist writes news and articles for newspapers. An author writes books, an editor revises content, a publisher produces and sells it.

Government by the people.

(a) Monarchy (b) Democracy (c) Aristocracy (d) Anarchy

Answer: (b) Democracy

> **Solution:** Democracy is rule by the people. Monarchy is rule by a king, aristocracy by the nobility, and anarchy is the absence of government.

MEDIUM

One who eats everything (both plants and meat).

(a) Carnivore (b) Herbivore (c) Omnivore (d) Insectivore

Answer: (c) Omnivore

> **Solution:** An omnivore eats both plant and animal food. A carnivore eats meat, a herbivore eats plants, an insectivore eats insects.

A speech made without preparation.

(a) Maiden (b) Extempore (c) Eloquent (d) Verbose

Answer: (b) Extempore

> **Solution:** An extempore speech is delivered without prior preparation. A maiden speech is one's first, eloquent means fluent, verbose means wordy.

A person who does not believe in the existence of God.

(a) Theist (b) Atheist (c) Agnostic (d) Heretic

Answer: (b) Atheist

> **Solution:** An atheist denies the existence of God. A theist believes in God, an agnostic is unsure, a heretic holds views against accepted doctrine.

Words written on the tomb of a person.

(a) Epitaph (b) Epigram (c) Epilogue (d) Epistle

Answer: (a) Epitaph

> **Solution:** An epitaph is the inscription on a gravestone. An epigram is a witty saying, an epilogue ends a book, an epistle is a formal letter.

A cure for all diseases.

(a) Antidote (b) Panacea (c) Tonic (d) Sedative

Answer: (b) Panacea

> **Solution:** A panacea is a remedy for all ills. An antidote counters a single poison, a tonic invigorates, a sedative calms.

One who is greedy and eats too much.

(a) Glutton (b) Epicure (c) Cannibal (d) Gourmet

Answer: (a) Glutton

> **Solution:** A glutton eats excessively and greedily. An epicure and a gourmet appreciate fine food in moderation; a cannibal eats human flesh.

HARD

A person who is unable to pay their debts.

(a) Bankrupt (b) Insolvent (c) Pauper (d) Beggar

Answer: (b) Insolvent

> **Solution:** "Insolvent" describes a person unable to pay debts. A pauper is very poor, a beggar lives by begging, and bankrupt is a legal status declared by a court.

Something that can be heard.

(a) Audible (b) Legible (c) Tangible (d) Visible

Answer: (a) Audible

> **Solution:** "Audible" means capable of being heard. Legible can be read, tangible can be touched, visible can be seen.

A person who hates mankind.

(a) Philanthropist (b) Misanthrope (c) Misogynist (d) Egoist

Answer: (b) Misanthrope

> **Solution:** A misanthrope dislikes humankind. A philanthropist loves and helps people, a misogynist hates women specifically, an egoist is self-centred.

The study of the origin and history of words.

(a) Etymology (b) Entomology (c) Ecology (d) Philology

Answer: (a) Etymology

> **Solution:** Etymology studies word origins. Entomology is the study of insects, ecology of organisms and environment, philology of language in historical texts broadly.

One who talks in their sleep.

(a) Somnambulist (b) Somniloquist (c) Insomniac (d) Sleepwalker

Answer: (b) Somniloquist

> **Solution:** A somniloquist talks while asleep. A somnambulist (sleepwalker) walks while asleep, and an insomniac cannot sleep.

SSC PYQ PATTERN

> *(SSC CGL pattern)*

Select the one word substitution for the given phrase. **"A place where bees are kept."**

(a) Apiary (b) Aviary (c) Sanctuary (d) Hive

Answer: (a) Apiary

> **Solution:** An apiary is a place where beehives are kept. An aviary houses birds; a hive is the single structure bees live in, not the place where they are kept.

Select the one word substitution for the given phrase. **"That which cannot be corrected."**

(a) Incurable (b) Incorrigible (c) Indelible (d) Illegible

Answer: (b) Incorrigible

> **Solution:** "Incorrigible" means not able to be corrected or reformed. Incurable refers to diseases, indelible to marks that cannot be removed, illegible to unreadable writing.

Select the one word substitution for the given phrase. **"A government run by officials."**

(a) Democracy (b) Bureaucracy (c) Theocracy (d) Plutocracy

Answer: (b) Bureaucracy

> **Solution:** Bureaucracy is government by appointed officials. Theocracy is rule by religious authority, plutocracy by the wealthy, democracy by the people.

Select the one word substitution for the given phrase. **"One who loves all human beings."**

(a) Misanthrope (b) Philanthropist (c) Egoist (d) Cynic

Answer: (b) Philanthropist

> **Solution:** A philanthropist loves and helps humankind. A misanthrope hates people, an egoist is self-centred, a cynic distrusts others' motives.

Select the one word substitution for the given phrase. **"A handwriting that cannot be read."**

(a) Audible (b) Eligible (c) Illegible (d) Invisible

Answer: (c) Illegible

> **Solution:** "Illegible" means impossible to read. Audible relates to hearing, eligible to qualification, invisible to sight.

> - Learn the common **suffixes**: *-cide* (kill), *-vorous* (eat), *-cracy/-archy* (rule), *-logy* (study).

> - Pair confusable words (apiary/aviary, etymology/entomology) and drill them **side by side**.

> - Spot the **prefix of negation** (*in-, il-, im-*) for "cannot be ___" phrases.

> - Make a personal **glossary** and revise 10 substitutions daily.

Spelling Spotting

22 Q

EASY

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Definately (b) Definitely (c) Definitly (d) Definetely

Answer: (b) Definitely

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "definitely" (root *finite*). The others wrongly insert an 'a' or drop the 'e'.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Receive (b) Believe (c) Acheive (d) Relieve

Answer: (c) Acheive

> **Solution:** The correct form is "achieve" (i before e). The other three are correctly spelt.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Seperate (b) Separate (c) Seperete (d) Sepparate

Answer: (b) Separate

> **Solution:** "Separate" contains "a rat" in the middle (sep-a-rate). The others misplace or double letters.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Calendar (b) Tomorrow (c) Goverment (d) Address

Answer: (c) Goverment

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "government" with an 'n' (govern + ment). The other three are correct.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Begining (b) Beginning (c) Begginning (d) Beginnig

Answer: (b) Beginning

> **Solution:** "Beginning" doubles the final 'n' before -ing. The others drop or misplace the doubled consonant.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Friend (b) Truely (c) Honest (d) Quiet

Answer: (b) Truely

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "truly" — the 'e' of true is dropped. The others are correctly spelt.

MEDIUM

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Accomodate (b) Acommodate (c) Accommodate (d) Acomodate

Answer: (c) Accommodate

> **Solution:** "Accommodate" has double 'c' and double 'm'. All other options drop one of these.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Embarrass (b) Occurrence (c) Posession (d) Necessary

Answer: (c) Posession

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "possession" with double 's' twice. The other three are correct.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Privilege (b) Priviledge (c) Privelege (d) Privilage

Answer: (a) Privilege

> **Solution:** "Privilege" has no 'd' and uses two 'i's then 'e'. The others insert a 'd' or wrong vowels.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Maintenance (b) Existence (c) Persistance (d) Resistance

Answer: (c) Persistance

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "persistence" with -ence. The other words are correctly spelt.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Concious (b) Conscious (c) Consious (d) Conscius

Answer: (b) Conscious

> **Solution:** "Conscious" has the 'sci' cluster. The others drop the 's' or 'c'.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Rhythm (b) Tomorow (c) Bicycle (d) Vacuum

Answer: (b) Tomorow

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "tomorrow" with double 'r'. The other three are correct.

HARD

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Liesure (b) Leisure (c) Lisure (d) Leasure

Answer: (b) Leisure

> **Solution:** "Leisure" is one of the exceptions where 'e' comes before 'i'. The others reorder or drop letters.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Conscientious (b) Mischievous (c) Millennium (d) Entreprenuer

Answer: (d) Entreprenuer

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "entrepreneur" (-neur, not -nuer). The other three are correctly spelt.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Bureaucracy (b) Bureacracy (c) Burocracy (d) Bureaucrasy

Answer: (a) Bureaucracy

> **Solution:** "Bureaucracy" keeps the French "bureau" plus -cracy. The others drop the 'a' or use 's'.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Questionnaire (b) Liaison (c) Pronounciation (d) Hierarchy

Answer: (c) Pronounciation

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "pronunciation" (no 'o' after 'pron'). The other three are correct.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Occassion (b) Ocassion (c) Occasion (d) Occasionn

Answer: (c) Occasion

> **Solution:** "Occasion" has double 'c' but single 's'. The others wrongly double the 's' or 'n', or drop a 'c'.

SSC PYQ PATTERN

> *(SSC CGL pattern)*

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Grammer (b) Parallel (c) Harassment (d) Committee

Answer: (a) Grammer

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "grammar" with an 'a', not "grammer". The other three are correctly spelt.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Maintainance (b) Maintenance (c) Maintainence (d) Maintnance

Answer: (b) Maintenance

> **Solution:** "Maintenance" drops the 'ai' of maintain before -tenance. The others keep extra letters.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Foreign (b) Sovereign (c) Forfiet (d) Counterfeit

Answer: (c) Forfiet

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "forfeit" (e before i here). The other three are correctly spelt.

Select the CORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Wierd (b) Weird (c) Werid (d) Weild

Answer: (b) Weird

> **Solution:** "Weird" is an exception to the i-before-e rule (e-i order). The others reorder the vowels.

Select the INCORRECTLY spelt word.

(a) Exaggerate (b) Exhilarate (c) Exilerate (d) Exasperate

Answer: (c) Exilerate

> **Solution:** The correct spelling is "exhilarate" with an 'h'. Option (c) is a misspelling; (a), (b) and (d) are correct.

> - Use **mnemonics**: "necessary" = one Collar, two Socks (one c, two s).

> - Recall **"i before e except after c"**, and memorise the exceptions (weird, leisure, seize).

> - Flag your **personal spelling demons** (accommodate, embarrass) and over-practise them.

> - Break long words into **syllables** (en-tre-pre-neur) before judging the spelling.

Error Detection 23 Q

EASY

Spot the error.

(a) One of my friends (b) are going (c) to the market today (d) No error

Answer: (b) are going

> **Solution:** "One of my friends" is singular (the subject is "One"), so the verb must be "is going", not "are going".

Spot the error.

(a) She do not (b) like (c) cold weather (d) No error

Answer: (a) She do not

> **Solution:** The third-person singular "She" requires "does not", not "do not".

Spot the error.

(a) The boy (b) along with his friends (c) were playing (d) No error

Answer: (c) were playing

> **Solution:** The subject is "The boy" (singular); the phrase "along with his friends" does not change the number, so it should be "was playing".

Spot the error.

(a) He is (b) more taller (c) than his brother (d) No error

Answer: (b) more taller

> **Solution:** "Taller" is already comparative, so "more" is redundant. It should simply be "taller".

Spot the error.

(a) I have (b) been working here (c) since five years (d) No error

Answer: (c) since five years

> **Solution:** "Since" marks a point in time; for a period we use "for". It should be "for five years".

Spot the error.

(a) Each of the students (b) have submitted (c) their assignment (d) No error

Answer: (b) have submitted

> **Solution:** "Each" is singular, so the verb must be "has submitted", not "have submitted".

MEDIUM

Spot the error.

(a) The teacher asked (b) the students (c) to not make noise (d) No error

Answer: (c) to not make noise

> **Solution:** The natural construction is "not to make noise"; splitting the infinitive as "to not make" is non-standard here.

Spot the error.

(a) Neither the manager (b) nor the employees (c) was present (d) No error

Answer: (c) was present

> **Solution:** With "neither...nor", the verb agrees with the nearer subject "employees" (plural), so it should be "were present".

Spot the error.

(a) He gave me (b) an advice (c) that proved useful (d) No error

Answer: (b) an advice

> **Solution:** "Advice" is an uncountable noun and cannot take "an". It should be "a piece of advice" or just "advice".

Spot the error.

(a) The committee (b) have decided (c) to postpone the meeting (d) No error

Answer: (b) have decided

> **Solution:** "Committee" acting as a single unit is singular, so "has decided" is correct.

Spot the error.

(a) Hardly had he (b) entered the room (c) than the lights went off (d) No error

Answer: (c) than the lights went off

> **Solution:** "Hardly...when" is the correct pairing, not "hardly...than". It should be "when the lights went off".

Spot the error.

(a) Both the sisters (b) are good (c) in mathematics (d) No error

Answer: (c) in mathematics

> **Solution:** The correct preposition after "good" for a subject of skill is "at", so it should be "good at mathematics".

Spot the error.

(a) She is senior (b) than me (c) by two years (d) No error

Answer: (b) than me

> **Solution:** "Senior" is followed by "to", not "than". It should be "senior to me".

HARD

Spot the error.

(a) No sooner did (b) the bell ring (c) when the children rushed out (d) No error

Answer: (c) when the children rushed out

> **Solution:** "No sooner" pairs with "than", not "when". It should be "than the children rushed out".

Spot the error.

(a) The number of (b) applicants (c) have increased this year (d) No error

Answer: (c) have increased this year

> **Solution:** "The number of" takes a singular verb, so it should be "has increased". (Compare "a number of", which is plural.)

Spot the error.

(a) If I were (b) you, I would (c) have accepted the offer (d) No error

Answer: (d) No error

> **Solution:** "If I were you, I would have accepted" is grammatically correct in the conditional. No part needs correction.

Spot the error.

(a) He is one of (b) those students who (c) always works hard (d) No error

Answer: (c) always works hard

> **Solution:** In "one of those students who...", the verb agrees with the plural "students", so it should be "work hard".

Spot the error.

(a) Scarcely had I (b) reached the station (c) than the train left (d) No error

Answer: (c) than the train left

> **Solution:** "Scarcely" pairs with "when", not "than". It should be "when the train left".

SSC PYQ PATTERN

> *(SSC CGL pattern)*

Identify the segment that contains the grammatical error.

(a) Many people (b) prefers tea (c) to coffee (d) No error

Answer: (b) prefers tea

> **Solution:** "Many people" is plural, so the verb should be "prefer", not "prefers".

Identify the segment that contains the grammatical error.

(a) He has been (b) ill (c) since last Monday (d) No error

Answer: (d) No error

> **Solution:** "Since last Monday" correctly marks a point in time with the present perfect "has been". The sentence is correct.

Identify the segment that contains the grammatical error.

(a) The jury (b) was divided (c) in their opinion (d) No error

Answer: (b) was divided

> **Solution:** When members act individually (divided in opinion), "jury" takes a plural verb, so it should be "were divided".

Identify the segment that contains the grammatical error.

(a) She prefers (b) reading (c) than watching television (d) No error

Answer: (c) than watching television

> **Solution:** "Prefer" is followed by "to", not "than". It should be "to watching television".

Identify the segment that contains the grammatical error.

(a) Neither of (b) the two answers (c) are correct (d) No error

Answer: (c) are correct

> **Solution:** "Neither" is singular, so the verb should be "is correct", not "are correct".

> - Memorise the **correlative pairs**: no sooner...than, hardly/scarcely...when, neither...nor.

> - For agreement, **ignore the phrase between commas** and match the verb to the real subject.

> - Keep a list of **preposition partners**: senior to, prefer to, good at, married to.

> - Treat **uncountable nouns** (advice, information, furniture) as never taking "a/an" or plural -s.

Fill in the Blanks / Cloze

22 Q

EASY

She was so tired that she could _____ keep her eyes open.

(a) hardly (b) easily (c) clearly (d) surely

Answer: (a) hardly

> **Solution:** Being tired logically means she could "hardly" (barely) keep her eyes open. The other adverbs contradict the sense of difficulty.

He apologised _____ his rude behaviour.

(a) on (b) for (c) with (d) at

Answer: (b) for

> **Solution:** The verb "apologise" collocates with the preposition "for" before the reason. The other prepositions are incorrect with "apologise".

The sun _____ in the east.

(a) rise (b) rises (c) rose (d) rising

Answer: (b) rises

> **Solution:** A universal truth takes the simple present, and the singular "sun" requires "rises".

I have not seen him _____ last week.

(a) for (b) from (c) since (d) by

Answer: (c) since

> **Solution:** "Since" marks a point in past time (last week) with the present perfect "have not seen".

She is fond _____ classical music.

(a) of (b) for (c) with (d) to

Answer: (a) of

> **Solution:** The adjective "fond" is always followed by the preposition "of".

Please switch _____ the lights before leaving.

(a) on (b) off (c) in (d) up

Answer: (b) off

> **Solution:** "Before leaving" implies turning the lights "off". "Switch on" would contradict the context.

MEDIUM

Despite working hard, he _____ to clear the exam.

(a) succeeded (b) failed (c) managed (d) tried

Answer: (b) failed

> **Solution:** "Despite" signals a contrast: hard work yet a negative outcome, so "failed" fits. "Succeeded" and "managed" would not contrast.

The new policy will _____ a positive impact on the economy.

(a) make (b) have (c) do (d) take

Answer: (b) have

> **Solution:** The standard collocation is "have an impact on". The other verbs do not pair correctly with "impact".

He is not only intelligent _____ also hardworking.

(a) and (b) but (c) or (d) yet

Answer: (b) but

> **Solution:** The correlative pair is "not only...but also". The other conjunctions break the structure.

The medicine should be taken _____ meals.

(a) after (b) afterwards (c) later (d) lately

Answer: (a) after

> **Solution:** A preposition is needed before "meals"; "after" fits both grammar and sense. The other words are adverbs.

Her explanation was so _____ that everyone understood at once.

(a) confusing (b) lucid (c) vague (d) complicated

Answer: (b) lucid

> **Solution:** If everyone understood at once, the explanation was clear, i.e. "lucid". The other adjectives mean the opposite.

We must _____ by the rules of the game.

(a) abide (b) follow (c) keep (d) stay

Answer: (a) abide

> **Solution:** The fixed phrase is "abide by" meaning to obey. "Follow" would not take "by".

HARD

The minister's speech was met with _____ applause from the audience.

(a) reluctant (b) thunderous (c) silent (d) faint

Answer: (b) thunderous

> **Solution:** "Applause" collocates strongly with "thunderous" to mean very loud approval. The other adjectives weaken or contradict the sense of enthusiastic applause.

His arguments were so _____ that no one could refute them.

(a) weak (b) flimsy (c) cogent (d) vague

Answer: (c) cogent

> **Solution:** If no one could refute them, the arguments were "cogent" (clear and convincing). The other words suggest weak arguments.

The detective found a _____ clue that solved the entire case.

(a) trivial (b) crucial (c) minor (d) useless

Answer: (b) crucial

> **Solution:** A clue that solved the whole case must be "crucial" (decisive). The other options downplay its importance.

She remained _____ in the face of severe criticism.

(a) composed (b) agitated (c) furious (d) nervous

Answer: (a) composed

> **Solution:** "Remained _____ in the face of criticism" implies staying calm, i.e. "composed". The others denote loss of calm.

The two nations finally decided to _____ their long-standing dispute.

(a) aggravate (b) prolong (c) resolve (d) ignore

Answer: (c) resolve

> **Solution:** "Finally decided to" suggests ending the dispute, so "resolve" fits. The other verbs would worsen or continue it.

SSC PYQ PATTERN

> *(SSC CGL pattern)*

Select the most appropriate word to fill in the blank. The brave soldier was awarded a medal for his _____.

(a) cowardice (b) gallantry (c) timidity (d) fear

Answer: (b) gallantry

> **Solution:** A brave soldier is rewarded for "gallantry" (bravery). The other options denote the opposite.

Select the most appropriate word to fill in the blank. The scientist's discovery had a profound _____ on modern medicine.

(a) affect (b) effect (c) defect (d) infect

Answer: (b) effect

> **Solution:** As a noun meaning influence, "effect" is correct (with the collocation "effect on"). "Affect" is a verb.

Select the most appropriate word to fill in the blank. He spoke with such _____ that the whole hall fell silent.

(a) hesitation (b) authority (c) confusion (d) weakness

Answer: (b) authority

> **Solution:** Speaking "with authority" commands attention and silence. The other options would not silence a hall.

Select the most appropriate word to fill in the blank. We should always _____ to our elders.

(a) listen (b) hear (c) obey (d) defy

Answer: (c) obey

> **Solution:** The expected value is respect, so "obey" fits the sense and the structure best. "Defy" is the opposite.

Select the most appropriate word to fill in the blank. The bridge _____ down due to the heavy floods.

(a) broke (b) breaks (c) breaking (d) broken

Answer: (a) broke

> **Solution:** A completed past event ("due to the heavy floods") requires the simple past "broke".

- Learn high-frequency **collocations** (have an impact, abide by, fond of) as fixed units.

- In cloze tests, **read the full passage once** before filling any blank.

- Use **signal words** (despite, not only, therefore) to predict the logical answer.

- Distinguish confusable pairs like **affect (verb) / effect (noun)** with a quick test sentence.

Sentence Improvement

22 Q

EASY

Improve the underlined part. She don't like spicy food.

(a) doesn't like (b) didn't liked (c) not like (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) doesn't like

Solution: The singular subject "She" needs "doesn't", not "don't". The other options are ungrammatical.

Improve the underlined part. He is junior than me in the office.

(a) than I (b) to me (c) from me (d) No improvement

Answer: (b) to me

Solution: "Junior" is followed by "to", not "than". So "junior to me" is correct.

Improve the underlined part. The children was playing in the park.

(a) were playing (b) is playing (c) has played (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) were playing

Solution: The plural subject "children" needs the plural verb "were playing".

Improve the underlined part. I look forward to meet you soon.

(a) to meeting you (b) to met you (c) for meeting you (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) to meeting you

Solution: In "look forward to", the "to" is a preposition, so it is followed by the gerund "meeting".

Improve the underlined part. He has been working here since five years.

(a) for five years (b) from five years (c) in five years (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) for five years

Solution: A duration takes "for"; "since" is used for a point in time. So "for five years" is correct.

Improve the underlined part. She sings good.

(a) well (b) better (c) goodly (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) well

Solution: The verb "sings" needs the adverb "well", not the adjective "good".

MEDIUM

Improve the underlined part. Hardly had I reached the station than the train left.

(a) when the train left (b) then the train left (c) that the train left (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) when the train left

Solution: "Hardly" pairs with "when", so "when the train left" is correct.

Improve the underlined part. The teacher asked the students to not talk during the exam.

(a) not to talk (b) to don't talk (c) to not talking (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) not to talk

> **Solution:** The standard form places "not" before the infinitive: "not to talk".

Improve the underlined part. If I was you, I would accept the offer.

(a) were (b) am (c) had been (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) were

> **Solution:** A hypothetical condition uses the subjunctive "were" for all subjects, so "If I were you" is correct.

Improve the underlined part. He is one of the best players who has ever represented the country.

(a) have (b) is (c) was (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) have

> **Solution:** In "one of the best players who...", the verb agrees with the plural "players", so "have" is correct.

Improve the underlined part. The quality of the products are improving.

(a) is (b) were (c) have been (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) is

> **Solution:** The subject is "The quality" (singular); "of the products" is a modifier. So the verb should be "is".

Improve the underlined part. She prefers coffee than tea.

(a) to tea (b) over tea (c) from tea (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) to tea

> **Solution:** "Prefer" is followed by "to", so "prefers coffee to tea" is correct.

HARD

Improve the underlined part. No sooner did the teacher enter than the students stood up.

(a) when the students stood up (b) then the students stood up (c) that the students stood up (d) No improvement

Answer: (d) No improvement

> **Solution:** "No sooner" correctly pairs with "than", so the underlined part is already right.

Improve the underlined part. The committee were unable to reach a decision.

(a) was unable (b) are unable (c) have been unable (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) was unable

> **Solution:** When the committee acts as a single body, it takes a singular verb, so "was unable" is correct.

Improve the underlined part. Each of the candidates have submitted their forms.

(a) has (b) are (c) were (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) has

> **Solution:** "Each" is singular and requires "has submitted".

Improve the underlined part. Scarcely had she left when the phone rang.

(a) than the phone rang (b) then the phone rang (c) that the phone rang (d) No improvement

Answer: (d) No improvement

> **Solution:** "Scarcely" pairs with "when", so the underlined part is already correct.

Improve the underlined part. The number of accidents **have decreased this year.**

(a) has (b) are (c) were (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) has

> **Solution:** "The number of" takes a singular verb, so "has decreased" is correct.

SSC PYQ PATTERN

> *(SSC CGL pattern)*

Select the most appropriate option to improve the underlined segment. He **succeeded to pass the examination.**

(a) succeeded in passing (b) succeeded for passing (c) succeeded to passing (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) succeeded in passing

> **Solution:** "Succeed" is followed by "in" + gerund, so "succeeded in passing" is correct.

Select the most appropriate option to improve the underlined segment. She is **more cleverer than her sister.**

(a) cleverer (b) most clever (c) more clever (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) cleverer

> **Solution:** "Cleverer" is already comparative; adding "more" is a double comparative error.

Select the most appropriate option to improve the underlined segment. The thief **ran away as soon as he saw the police.**

(a) had ran away (b) run away (c) was ran away (d) No improvement

Answer: (d) No improvement

> **Solution:** "Ran away" is the correct simple past form; the sentence needs no change.

Select the most appropriate option to improve the underlined segment. He insisted **on going there alone.**

(a) to go (b) for going (c) at going (d) No improvement

Answer: (d) No improvement

> **Solution:** "Insist on" + gerund is the correct construction, so "on going" is right.

Select the most appropriate option to improve the underlined segment. Neither of the boys **were present in the class.**

(a) was (b) are (c) have been (d) No improvement

Answer: (a) was

> **Solution:** "Neither" is singular and takes a singular verb, so "was present" is correct.

> - Memorise **verb + preposition** patterns: succeed in, insist on, prefer to, look forward to (+ -ing).

> - For comparatives, never combine **"more" with -er** (more taller, more cleverer are wrong).

> - Use **"No improvement"** confidently when correlatives and agreement already match.

> - Strip out **modifier phrases** to test if the verb agrees with the true subject.

Voice & Narration

22 Q

EASY

Change to passive voice: **She writes a letter.**

(a) A letter is written by her. (b) A letter was written by her. (c) A letter is being written by her. (d) A letter has written by her.

Answer: (a) A letter is written by her.

> **Solution:** Simple present active becomes "is/are + past participle". "Writes" → "is written", agent "by her".

Change to passive voice: **They are building a house.**

(a) A house is built by them. (b) A house is being built by them. (c) A house was being built by them.
(d) A house has been built by them.

Answer: (b) A house is being built by them.

> **Solution:** Present continuous passive is "is/are being + past participle": "is being built".

Change to indirect speech: **He said, "I am tired."**

(a) He said that he was tired. (b) He said that I am tired. (c) He says that he is tired. (d) He said that he is tired.

Answer: (a) He said that he was tired.

> **Solution:** The reporting verb "said" is past, so present "am" shifts to "was" and "I" becomes "he".

Change to passive voice: **He opened the door.**

(a) The door was opened by him. (b) The door is opened by him. (c) The door has opened by him. (d) The door opened by him.

Answer: (a) The door was opened by him.

> **Solution:** Simple past active becomes "was/were + past participle": "was opened by him".

Change to indirect speech: **She said, "I will help you."**

(a) She said that she will help me. (b) She said that she would help me. (c) She said that she helped me.
(d) She says she would help me.

Answer: (b) She said that she would help me.

> **Solution:** "Will" changes to "would" after a past reporting verb, and "you" becomes "me".

Change to passive voice: **The teacher praised the student.**

(a) The student is praised by the teacher. (b) The student was praised by the teacher. (c) The student has praised the teacher.
(d) The student praised by the teacher.

Answer: (b) The student was praised by the teacher.

> **Solution:** Simple past passive is "was + past participle": "was praised by the teacher".

MEDIUM

Change to passive voice: **Someone has stolen my bicycle.**

(a) My bicycle has been stolen. (b) My bicycle was stolen. (c) My bicycle is stolen. (d) My bicycle had been stolen.

Answer: (a) My bicycle has been stolen.

> **Solution:** Present perfect passive is "has/have been + past participle". The vague agent "someone" is usually dropped.

Change to indirect speech: **He said to me, "Where do you live?"**

(a) He asked me where I lived. (b) He asked me where do I live. (c) He asked me where I live. (d) He told me where I lived.

Answer: (a) He asked me where I lived.

> **Solution:** A wh-question uses "asked", drops the auxiliary, keeps statement order, and shifts "do you live" to "I lived".

Change to indirect speech: **She said, "Please close the window."**

(a) She requested to close the window. (b) She requested me to close the window. (c) She said to close the window.
(d) She ordered closing the window.

Answer: (b) She requested me to close the window.

> **Solution:** A polite command uses "requested + object + to + verb". "Please" becomes "requested".

Change to passive voice: **The committee will announce the results.**

(a) The results will announced. (b) The results will be announced by the committee. (c) The results are announced.
(d) The results have been announced.

Answer: (b) The results will be announced by the committee.

> **Solution:** Future simple passive is "will be + past participle": "will be announced".

Change to indirect speech: **The teacher said, "Do not make noise."**

(a) The teacher said do not make noise. (b) The teacher ordered not to make noise. (c) The teacher asked making noise.
(d) The teacher told making noise.

Answer: (b) The teacher ordered not to make noise.

> **Solution:** A negative command uses "ordered/forbade + not + to + verb": "ordered not to make noise".

Change to passive voice: **People speak English all over the world.**

(a) English is spoken all over the world. (b) English was spoken all over the world. (c) English speaks all over the world.
(d) English is being spoken all over the world.

Answer: (a) English is spoken all over the world.

> **Solution:** Simple present passive is "is spoken"; the general agent "people" is dropped.

HARD

Change to indirect speech: **He said, "What a beautiful sight it is!"**

(a) He said that it was a beautiful sight. (b) He exclaimed that it was a very beautiful sight.
(c) He asked what a beautiful sight it was. (d) He told that it is a beautiful sight.

Answer: (b) He exclaimed that it was a very beautiful sight.

> **Solution:** An exclamatory sentence uses "exclaimed", "what a...!" becomes "that...very", and "is" shifts to "was".

Change to passive voice: **They were repairing the road when I passed by.**

(a) The road was repaired when I passed by. (b) The road was being repaired when I passed by.
(c) The road is being repaired when I passed by. (d) The road had been repaired when I passed by.

Answer: (b) The road was being repaired when I passed by.

> **Solution:** Past continuous passive is "was/were being + past participle": "was being repaired".

Change to indirect speech: **She said, "I have finished my work now."**

(a) She said that she has finished her work then. (b) She said that she had finished her work then.
(c) She said that she finished her work now. (d) She said that she had finished her work now.

Answer: (b) She said that she had finished her work then.

> **Solution:** Present perfect "have finished" shifts to past perfect "had finished", and "now" becomes "then".

Change to passive voice: **One should keep one's promises.**

(a) Promises should be kept. (b) Promises should keep. (c) Promises are kept. (d) Promises were kept.

Answer: (a) Promises should be kept.

> **Solution:** With a modal, the passive is "modal + be + past participle": "should be kept". The general agent is omitted.

Change to indirect speech: **He said, "May God bless you!"**

(a) He said that God may bless me. (b) He prayed that God might bless me. (c) He asked God to bless me.

(d) He told that God would bless me.

Answer: (b) He prayed that God might bless me.

> **Solution:** An optative (wish/prayer) uses "prayed/wished", "may" shifts to "might", and "you" becomes "me".

SSC PYQ PATTERN

> *(SSC CGL pattern)*

Select the correct passive form: **The chef is preparing a special dish.**

(a) A special dish is prepared by the chef. (b) A special dish is being prepared by the chef.

(c) A special dish was prepared by the chef. (d) A special dish has been prepared by the chef.

Answer: (b) A special dish is being prepared by the chef.

> **Solution:** Present continuous passive is "is being + past participle": "is being prepared".

Select the correct indirect speech: **He said to her, "Are you coming with me?"**

(a) He asked her if she was coming with him. (b) He asked her if she is coming with him.

(c) He told her that she was coming with him. (d) He asked her are you coming with me.

Answer: (a) He asked her if she was coming with him.

> **Solution:** A yes/no question uses "asked...if", shifts "are you coming" to "she was coming" and "me" to "him".

Select the correct passive form: **They have completed the project.**

(a) The project is completed by them. (b) The project was completed by them. (c) The project has been completed by them.

(d) The project had been completed by them.

Answer: (c) The project has been completed by them.

> **Solution:** Present perfect passive is "has/have been + past participle": "has been completed".

Select the correct indirect speech: **The officer said to the soldiers, "March forward."**

(a) The officer told the soldiers to march forward. (b) The officer ordered the soldiers to march forward.

(c) The officer asked the soldiers march forward. (d) The officer said the soldiers to march forward.

Answer: (b) The officer ordered the soldiers to march forward.

> **Solution:** An authoritative command uses "ordered + object + to + verb": "ordered the soldiers to march forward".

Select the correct active form: **A new bridge is being built by the government.**

(a) The government builds a new bridge. (b) The government is building a new bridge. (c) The government built a new bridge.

(d) The government has built a new bridge.

Answer: (b) The government is building a new bridge.

> **Solution:** "Is being built" is present continuous passive, so the active is present continuous: "is building".

> - For passive, remember the formula: **object + correct *be* + past participle (+ by + agent)**.

> - Match the *be* form to the **original tense** (is → is being; has → has been; will → will be).

> - In narration, use the right **reporting verb**: asked (question), ordered/requested (command), exclaimed (exclamation), prayed (wish).

> - Apply the **back-shift** of tense and change **now→then, today→that day, here→there** in indirect speech.

Reading Comprehension

18 Q

EASY

Passage 1

What is the main role of the queen bee?

(a) To gather nectar (b) To lay eggs and sustain the colony (c) To pollinate flowers (d) To make honey

Answer: (b) To lay eggs and sustain the colony

> **Solution:** The passage states the queen's main role is to lay eggs and ensure the colony's survival. Gathering nectar and pollinating are the workers' tasks.

Why is pollination by bees important?

(a) It produces honey (b) It helps bees travel (c) Many crops depend on it (d) It protects the queen

Answer: (c) Many crops depend on it

> **Solution:** The passage says a large share of the crops we eat depends on pollination, making it vital for agriculture.

What do worker bees do with nectar?

(a) Feed it to the queen only (b) Convert it into honey (c) Store it without change (d) Use it to build the hive

Answer: (b) Convert it into honey

> **Solution:** The passage clearly states that worker bees convert gathered nectar into honey.

What concern do scientists raise?

(a) Bees are too aggressive (b) Hives are growing too large (c) A decline in bees could threaten food supplies
(d) Honey is becoming scarce

Answer: (c) A decline in bees could threaten food supplies

> **Solution:** The last sentence warns that falling bee populations could seriously threaten global food supplies.

The word "industrious" in the passage most nearly means:

(a) Lazy (b) Hardworking (c) Dangerous (d) Colourful

Answer: (b) Hardworking

> **Solution:** "Industrious" means diligent and hardworking, which fits the description of busy bees. "Lazy" is the opposite.

MEDIUM

Passage 2

What did people traditionally believe about education?

(a) That it cultivates curiosity (b) That its value lay only in securing jobs (c) That it teaches critical thinking
(d) That it is unnecessary

Answer: (b) That its value lay only in securing jobs

> **Solution:** The opening sentence states the traditional belief that education's value lay only in the jobs it could secure.

According to the passage, what is the limitation of merely memorising facts?

(a) It improves curiosity (b) It guarantees success in life (c) It leaves a student unable to adapt to change
(d) It develops critical thinking

Answer: (c) It leaves a student unable to adapt to change

> **Solution:** The passage says a student who only memorises may pass exams but will struggle to adapt in a changing world.

What quality does the passage value in a well-educated student?

(a) The ability to memorise quickly (b) The ability to question, analyse and connect ideas (c) Obedience to teachers
(d) Speed in passing exams

Answer: (b) The ability to question, analyse and connect ideas

> **Solution:** The passage praises the student who learns to question, analyse and connect ideas as better prepared for new problems.

What is the author's view of the true purpose of education?

(a) To fill the mind with information (b) To teach the mind how to think (c) To guarantee high-paying jobs
(d) To memorise as many facts as possible

Answer: (b) To teach the mind how to think

> **Solution:** The concluding sentence states the true purpose is not to fill the mind with information but to teach it how to think.

The word "cultivate" in the passage most nearly means:

(a) Destroy (b) Develop (c) Ignore (d) Reduce

Answer: (b) Develop

> **Solution:** To "cultivate" curiosity means to develop or foster it. "Destroy", "ignore" and "reduce" are opposite in sense.

HARD

Inference-based questions on Passage 2

Which statement would the author most likely agree with?

(a) Examinations are the best measure of true learning. (b) Adaptability matters more than rote memorisation.
(c) Education has no link with employment. (d) Curiosity is irrelevant to learning.

Answer: (b) Adaptability matters more than rote memorisation.

> **Solution:** The passage favours adaptable, thinking students over those who merely memorise, so the author would agree adaptability matters more.

It can be inferred that the author considers critical thinking to be:

(a) A modern fashion with little value (b) Essential for solving unfamiliar problems (c) Less important than job training
(d) A barrier to passing exams

Answer: (b) Essential for solving unfamiliar problems

> **Solution:** The passage links questioning and analysing to being "better prepared to solve unfamiliar problems", implying critical thinking is essential.

The tone of the passage can best be described as:

(a) Sarcastic (b) Reflective and persuasive (c) Angry (d) Humorous

Answer: (b) Reflective and persuasive

> **Solution:** The author reflects on the purpose of education and argues a viewpoint, making the tone reflective and persuasive.

"To teach the mind how to think" suggests that education should be:

(a) Limited to factual recall (b) Focused on developing reasoning skills (c) Purely vocational (d) Discontinued after school

Answer: (b) Focused on developing reasoning skills

> **Solution:** Teaching the mind "how to think" emphasises reasoning over mere recall.

Which of the following best summarises the passage?

(a) Education is only about getting a job. (b) Education should develop thinking, not just store facts.
(c) Memorisation is the key to success. (d) Curiosity hinders academic progress.

Answer: (b) Education should develop thinking, not just store facts.

> **Solution:** This captures the central contrast of the passage between storing information and developing the ability to think.

SSC PYQ PATTERN — Para Jumble

(SSC CGL pattern)

In each question, the first (S1) and last (S6) sentences are fixed. Arrange the middle sentences (P, Q, R, S) in the correct order.

(a) QPRS (b) PQSR (c) QRPS (d) PRQS

Answer: (a) QPRS

Solution: S1 introduces the visit; Q takes him to the river; P pushes him under; R describes him surfacing and the question; S gives his answer "Air", which leads naturally into S6.

(a) QPRS (b) PQRS (c) QRPS (d) PRSQ

Answer: (a) QPRS

Solution: Q states the scale of production; P says discarded plastic reaches water bodies; R explains the harm there and microplastics; S follows microplastics into the food chain, leading to the call for action in S6.

(a) QPRS (b) PQRS (c) QRPS (d) PRSQ

Answer: (a) QPRS

Solution: Q explains what reading opens up; P narrows to books exploring places and eras; R continues with "through them" sharing great minds; S concludes the book as a companion, leading to S6.

- For detail questions, **scan for keywords** from the question stem inside the passage.

- For inference questions, ask: **"What must be true if the passage is true?"**

- In para jumbles, track **pronouns and connectors** (these, there, therefore) to chain sentences.

- Always identify the **independent opening sentence** before ordering the rest.